

The Real AI Divide Isn't Intelligence. It's Bandwidth.

by Abby Buchanan

There's a growing assumption that AI will divide people based on intelligence—who knows how to use it, who understands it, who can keep up.

But that framing misses something more fundamental.

Much of modern work isn't thinking—it's translating thought into formats systems can recognize. Emails. Decks. Applications. Documentation. Summaries. Endless small acts of conversion between human cognition and institutional structure.

The real divide isn't intelligence. It's bandwidth.

Not everyone is moving through the world with the same amount of cognitive or emotional margin. Some people have space—time to think, experiment, learn a tool badly before learning it well. Others are already operating at capacity, moving through systems in a constant state of compression.

AI tools are often framed as simplifiers. And sometimes they are. They can reduce friction, organize information, generate momentum, lower the barrier between idea and execution.

But they also introduce new layers of interaction, new decisions, new workflows, new expectations. For someone with available bandwidth, that can feel expansive. For someone already overwhelmed, it can feel like one more interface demanding adaptation.

A new tool is only helpful if you have enough margin to absorb it.

And margin isn't distributed evenly.

Bandwidth is shaped by economic pressure, caregiving demands, disability, burnout, job instability, chronic stress, and the invisible labor of navigating systems that were never designed with your nervous system in mind.

When those conditions destabilize, the impact isn't just financial. It's cognitive. Stress narrows experimentation. Exhaustion reduces curiosity. Survival mode makes even beneficial tools feel inaccessible because every additional step carries a cost.

That creates a feedback loop.

The people who could most benefit from AI-supported tools may also be the least resourced to adopt them quickly—not because they lack intelligence, but because they lack capacity. Meanwhile, people with more stability, time, and support are able to compound their advantage simply by having room to engage.

So the question isn't only whether AI increases productivity.

It's whether it expands participation.

Whether more people are actually able to contribute, think, create, and work in ways that were previously blocked by cognitive overload or structural friction. Whether these systems reduce human strain—or quietly redistribute opportunity toward the people who already have the most margin.

The future of AI won't be determined only by what the technology can do.

It will be shaped by who has the conditions to use it—and whether those conditions are widening or narrowing access to participation itself.